

DELHI Lok Sabha Speaker Somnath Chatterjee often strays off the beaten track. Known to use the carrot and stick with equal ease while dealing with the members, he stunned MPs last week by suggesting that voters should have the right to recall MPs who do not live up to expectations. Chatterjee voiced this at a meeting of the Commonwealth Parliamentary Association in Delhi.

Contrary to what some MPs believe, this view was not prompted just by their behaviour in the House. The Speaker has been propagating this ever since the cash-for-queries scam broke last year and this is just one suggestion as part of his larger initiative to promote a "mature democracy".

Last fortnight, the Standing Committee on Information Technology sent out a missive to all its members reminding them about the Speaker's guide-



It's All on the House

lines banning MPs from taking freebies from PSUs. According to these, the cost of "study visits" to PSUs should be borne by the Lok Sabha secretariat and not the PSU. Members should travel in shared cars or air-conditioned coaches. No MP should accept gifts from a PSU or take along a family mem-

ber. The members should also pay for any ISD, STD or laundry charges incurred during their stay.

According to the Speaker's office, these guidelines have been in place for 15 years but were not being adhered to. His other initiatives include organising lectures for MPs by eminent

personalities during Parliament sessions. Many first-time MPs including Rahul Gandhi have attended these lectures. The pro-active Speaker has also pulled up MPs for forming independent friendship groups with industry associations like CII and FICCI and the Indo-US Parliamentary Forum.

This is one Speaker who believes in speaking his mind. **by Priya Sahgal**

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

While the Marxists met in Kolkata to deliberate the fate of the UPA regime, Finance Minister P. Chidambaram announced at Wharton School last week that FDI in retail will soon become a reality. The Reds must finally be seeing red.

VOICES

“In politics, there is nothing like possibility and impossibility. In politics, talks will always continue.”

H. D. Kumaraswamy, Karnataka chief minister

“Why would there be appeals and impeachments or higher benches if every judge was right? Our MPs and MLAs should take note of this.”

T. R. Baalu, Union shipping minister

“We don't agree with the Supreme Court which first wanted to ban bandhs, then ban strikes. The logical conclusion would be to declare a ban on all forms of protest.”

Prakash Karat, CPI(M) general secretary

“We're the deciding force in around half-a-dozen municipalities (in Karnataka). We are in the best ever position and one should know who would gain if an election happens today.”

Rajiv Pratap Rudy, BJP spokesperson

“Yes, I heard about it (Indian cricket team's reception) and it would be interesting to see what kind of reception I get when I come to India by the end of this month.”

Vishwanathan Anand, world chess champion